SHOWTIME FLAG FOOTBALL LEAGUE

OFFICIAL RULEBOOK

2026



TABLE OF CONTENTS

Foreword 3

1.0. Game, Field, Ball and Equipment 5

2.0. Definitions 8

3.0. Periods and Timing 15

4.0. Live Ball and Dead Ball 17

5.0. Series of Downs 18

6.0. Throw-Offs, Punt Throws and Illegal Kicks 19

7.0. Snapping and Passing the Ball 22

8.0. Scoring 25

9.0. Conduct of Players 27

10.0. Penalty Enforcement 29

11.0. Officials and Match Authority 31

12.0. Challenges 32

13.0. Summary of Penalties 33

Foreword

Welcome to the Official Playing Rules of Showtime Flag Football.

Showtime was founded with a clear ambition: to build Africa's premier professional flag football league and contribute meaningfully to the global development of the sport. That ambition requires more than talented athletes, committed teams and passionate supporters. It requires rules that are clear, consistent and suited to the competition being built.

These Playing Rules establish the standard for every game conducted under Showtime Flag. They are designed to protect players, preserve competitive fairness and ensure that the game is administered professionally. They also provide a common understanding of the sport for players, coaches, officials, team owners, statisticians and league personnel.

The rules are founded on the International Federation of American Football International Flag Football Rules. Showtime recognises IFAF's contribution to the development of flag football and the importance of maintaining a connection to the internationally recognised form of the game.

Showtime Game Principles

Showtime is, however, a professional coed league with its own identity, competition structure and playing philosophy. The international framework has therefore been adapted to reflect the realities of the league and the experience Showtime intends to create. These modifications are intended to improve the pace and competitiveness of the game, strengthen player safety and create a more compelling product for spectators.

These Playing Rules are guided by five principles:

1. Fair and consistent competition;
2. Player welfare and safety;
3. Respect for the integrity and spirit of the game;
4. Professional officiating and administration; and
5. The continued development of flag football as a competitive and commercially sustainable sport.

Showtime Penalty Philosophy

Showtime penalties are intended to restore fairness rather than create an additional advantage. A penalty should compensate a team for the opportunity lost because of a foul, but should not ordinarily award penalty yardage on top of advancement already achieved during the same play.

The following principles shall guide the interpretation and enforcement of penalties:

1. Foul After a Completed Pass: Where a receiver catches the ball and a foul is subsequently committed against that player, the ball may be advanced in accordance with the applicable penalty. The enforcement must recognise that the foul may have prevented the receiver from making further lawful advancement.
2. Foul During an Incomplete Pass: Where a forward pass is thrown but not caught, any yardage penalty shall ordinarily be enforced from the scrimmage line, unless a specific rule provides for placement at the spot of the foul.
3. Foul Before a Pass: Where the ball has not been thrown, any yardage penalty shall ordinarily be enforced from the scrimmage line, unless a specific rule provides otherwise.
4. Foul Against a Defender: Where an offensive player commits a foul that prevents a defender from making a lawful play on the ball or the runner, the offense shall not retain any advancement gained because of that foul. The ball shall be returned to the scrimmage line or placed at the spot of the foul, as provided by the applicable rule. Unless expressly stated otherwise, enforcement shall not both move the offense behind the applicable enforcement spot and impose a loss of down.
5. Foul Affecting a Catchable Pass: Where a catchable pass is affected by a foul, enforcement may place the ball at the spot where the opportunity to make the catch was unlawfully denied or

apply the prescribed penalty from the scrimmage line. The penalty shall not place the offense beyond the spot where the catch could reasonably have been completed. Both remedies shall not be applied to the same foul.

6. No Double Advantage or Disadvantage: Penalty enforcement shall not ordinarily give either team more than the opportunity lost because of the foul. The offense shall not receive both the advancement achieved during the play and additional yardage for the same act. Equally, the defense shall not be required to surrender more field position than the offensive opportunity unlawfully denied. The applicable rule shall determine whether the result of the play is retained, the ball is placed at the spot of the foul, or the penalty is enforced from the scrimmage line.
7. Flag Required for Advancement and Scoring: A player must begin the down with both flags properly attached and visible. A player who enters or participates in a down without both flags commits a flag violation. Such a player may not advance the ball or score. If the player gains possession, the ball shall become dead immediately at the point of the catch or recovery, and no touchdown, try or other score shall be awarded.
    a. Early Flag-Pull Exception: Where a player legally begins the down with both flags and a defender removes a flag before that player gains possession, the act shall be treated as an early flag-pull foul. If the affected player subsequently catches or receives the ball, the ball shall become dead immediately at the point of the catch. No advancement beyond the point of the catch is permitted.
    b. If the point of the catch is inside the opponent's end zone, the catch shall count as a touchdown or try, as applicable. The player shall not be denied the score because the flag was unlawfully removed by a defender before possession was gained.
    c. No additional yardage shall be awarded beyond the point of the catch for the early flag pull. If the pass is not completed, the early flag-pull penalty shall be enforced from the scrimmage line in accordance with the applicable penalty rule.

These principles are intended to ensure that penalty enforcement remains proportionate to the disadvantage caused by the foul. They shall be applied together with the specific enforcement provisions contained in these Playing Rules. Where a specific penalty provision expressly provides otherwise, that provision shall apply.

Everyone who participates in Showtime Flag shares responsibility for protecting these principles. Players must compete with discipline and respect. Coaches must teach and manage the game with integrity. Officials must apply the rules impartially and consistently. Team owners, administrators and league personnel must conduct themselves in a manner that strengthens the reputation of the league and the sport.

These Playing Rules must be read alongside the Showtime Flag By-Laws and any applicable Season Competition Regulations. Matters concerning play on the field are governed by these Playing Rules. Matters concerning governance, ownership, membership, finance, registration, discipline and league administration are governed by the By-Laws and applicable league regulations.

Where any Showtime modification differs from the underlying international framework, the Showtime provision shall apply to all Showtime competitions.

The game will continue to evolve, and so will these rules. Showtime reserves the right to review and amend them when necessary to protect player welfare, improve competition, strengthen operational efficiency and advance the development of the sport.

We are building more than a league. We are building a professional standard for flag football in Africa—one defined by excellence, innovation, fairness and respect.

It's Showtime.

1.0. Game, Field, Ball and Equipment

1.1. General Provisions

1.1.1. **The Game and Field:** The game shall be played between two coed teams using a Showtime-approved ball and two flags per player. Showtime competitions may be played as 5v5 or 7v7. The official schedule and Season Competition Regulations shall identify the format for each competition or match.

1.1.1.1. The standard 7v7 field is 50 yards long and 30 yards wide, with two 10-yard end zones and two 5-yard no-running zones.

1.1.1.2. The standard 5v5 field is 50 yards long and 25-30 yards wide, with two 10-yard end zones and two 10-yard no-running zones.

1.1.1.3. In 5v5, a team may play with four players. If a team has fewer than four eligible players ready to play, the game shall be forfeited unless Showtime Football Operations authorises a delayed start under the Season Competition Regulations. In 7v7, no more than seven players per team may be on the field, and the minimum number required to start or continue shall be stated in the Season Competition Regulations.

1.1.1.4. Match rosters consist of a maximum of 15 players unless the Season Competition Regulations provide otherwise. Showtime is a coed competition and players of different genders may be registered and fielded together. Gender-lineup and All-Rounder restrictions are governed by the current Season Competition Regulations.

1.1.1.5. Every third down is the designated female-only down. The snap must be received by an eligible female quarterback, and any forward pass must be thrown by her. The approved female-designated ball shall be used for the down. A failure to comply is an illegal participation foul.

1.1.2. **Winning Team and Final Score:** Each team shall be allowed opportunities to advance the ball across the other team's goal line by running or passing it. The teams shall be awarded points for scoring according to rule and the team having the higher score at the end of the game, including extra periods, shall be the winner.

1.1.3. **Supervision:** The game shall be played under the supervision of 5 or more officials.

1.1.3.1. The Head Referee

1.1.3.2. 2x Video Assistant Referee

1.1.3.3. 2x Line Referee

1.1.3.4. The 7 yard line Referee

1.1.3.5. 2x Endzone Referee

1.1.3.6. Yard Marker

1.1.3.7. Timekeeper

1.1.3.8. Stat takers

1.1.4. **Team Captains and Coaches:** Each team shall designate to the Referee no more than 2 players as its captains and no more than 2 coaches. Only these captains and coaches may ask the Referee questions about rule clarifications, make decisions for the team or request a challenge.

1.2. The Ball

1.2.1. **Specifications:** The game ball shall be a Showtime-approved flag-football ball in serviceable condition. The Referee has final authority to approve or reject any ball before or during a match.

1.2.2. **Sizes:** The regular approved ball shall be used unless the Season Competition Regulations designate another approved ball for a player category or designated female-quarterback down. Each team may use its own approved ball, but ownership markings must not affect the ball's surface or performance.

1.3. Equipment

1.3.1. **Mandatory Equipment:** Players of opposing teams shall wear jerseys of contrasting colors. If the teams are using similar jerseys, the home team has the option which team has to change jerseys.

1.3.2. Players of a team shall wear jerseys of the same color, cut and style. The jerseys shall be

1.3.2.1. full-length and tucked into the pants with contrasting Arabic numerals at least 6 inches (15 cm) in height on the back. All players of a team shall have different whole numbers from 0 to 99.

1.3.2.2. Jerseys shall not be taped or tied in any manner.

1.3.3. Players of a team shall wear shorts or pants of the same single color except for branding, logos or numbers on the front side of each leg with a maximum size of 4×4 inches (10×10 cm). The shorts or pants shall have the same cut and style without pockets, press studs or clips. Players may not tape or secure their shorts or pants to meet the regulations. Skirts are illegal.

1.3.4. Players of a team shall wear tightly fixed flag belts with pop-sockets and 2 identical flags. Every effort shall be made to keep one flag on each side of the players waist.

1.3.4.1. The sockets shall be placed facing outwards and downwards.

1.3.4.2. The flags shall be clearly visible, hang down freely and must not be covered in any way by the player's uniform and all colors must be contrasting with the color of the pants.

1.3.4.3. The flags and sockets may not be greased, glued or altered in any way. Any player, who deliberately manipulates their flags shall be disqualified.

1.3.5. If an intra-oral mouthpiece is worn it shall be of a visible, non-white color and with no part extending more than 0.5 inch (1,25 cm) out of the mouth. The use of a mouthpiece is strongly recommended.

1.3.6. **Flag Specifications:** Each player shall wear a Showtime-approved belt with two matching flags positioned at the hips.

1.3.6.1. The flags must contrast with the player's shorts or pants, hang freely, face outwards and remain fully visible.

1.3.6.2. A flag belt, flag or socket may not be covered, greased, glued, altered or deliberately manipulated. A player who begins a down without two properly positioned flags is responsible for the resulting dead-ball or illegal-equipment ruling under these rules.

1.3.7. **Illegal Equipment** Shoes with cleats longer than 0.5 inch (1,25 cm), sharpened or pointed in any way or made of any metallic material.

1.3.7.1. Any kind of shoulder pads, helmets or head wear (caps, hoods, bandannas, headbands or similar).

1.3.7.2. Any kind of protectors which endanger other players (e.g. sharp-edged knee braces).

1.3.7.3. All kinds of glasses and frames made from breakable material which could splinter. NOTE: Certified sport glasses made of synthetic material under standard specifications are available.

1.3.7.4. Jewelry shall be removed or covered up completely.

1.3.7.5. Uniform attachments like towels or hand warmers.

1.3.7.6. Adhesive material, paint, grease or any other slippery substance applied to equipment or to a player's person, clothing or attachment that affects the ball or an opponent.

1.3.7.7. Any electronic, mechanical or other signal devices for the purpose of communicating with a coach or other person.

1.3.8. **Team Certification:** Before the game each team shall give a roster to the Referee and certify that all players have the mandatory equipment and have been informed what constitutes illegal equipment. The certification must include the following details:

1.3.8.1. The full team list with player names and numbers

1.3.8.2. Player positions including All-Round players

2.0. Definitions

2.1. Key definitions

2.1.1. **Showtime or the League:** Showtime Flag Football, acting through its authorised officers, administrators and Football Operations personnel.

2.1.2. **Playing Rules**: The rules governing play on the field in all Showtime matches, including any amendment formally adopted by the League.

2.1.3. **Season Competition Regulations**: The competition-specific regulations issued by Showtime for a season, tournament, division or match. They supplement these Playing Rules and may specify matters expressly left to those regulations.

2.1.4. **Football Operations**: The Showtime function or authorised personnel responsible for competition administration, match operations, officiating and the application of these Playing Rules.

2.1.5. **Match**: A game scheduled, sanctioned or otherwise approved by Showtime, including any required overtime or tiebreaker period.

2.1.6. **Match Format**: The number of players permitted on the field for each team. A Showtime match may be played as 5v5 or 7v7, as identified in the official schedule or Season Competition Regulations.

2.1.7. **Approved Ball**: A ball accepted by the Referee for use in the match and meeting any specifications or player-category requirements issued by Showtime.

2.1.8. **Female-Only Down**: Every third down, during which all participating offensive and defensive players must be female, the snap must be received by an eligible female quarterback, any forward pass must be thrown by her, and the approved female-designated ball must be used.

2.1.9. **Throw-Off**: The Showtime procedure for putting the ball in play by a throw at the beginning of a half, or at another time authorised by the Season Competition Regulations.

2.1.10. **Punt Throw**: A declared fourth-down play in which an eligible team may surrender possession by throwing the ball under the punt provisions of these Playing Rules.

2.1.11. **Declared Punt**: A punt throw announced by the captain or head coach to the Referee before the ready-for-play whistle.

2.1.12. **Fake Punt**: A declared punt that becomes a normal fourth-down scrimmage play because the punter abandons the punt or a punting-team player makes movement that converts the play under the punt rules.

2.1.13. **Punter**: The player designated to receive the snap and make the punt throw. The punter may not be the team's designated quarterback.

2.1.14. **Own Territory**: The part of the field of play between a team's own goal line and the middle line.

2.1.15. **Game Ban**: A suspension that makes a person ineligible to participate in the stated number of the team's next official Showtime games, subject to any applicable disciplinary decision or Competition Regulation.

2.2. Areas and Lines

2.2.1. **The Field:** Field of play: length 50 yards, additional end zones 10 yards, width 30 yards

2.2.2. **Field of Play:** The field of play is the area within the boundary lines (side lines and end lines) other than the end zones.

2.2.3. **End Zones:** The end zones are the 10-yard areas at both ends of the field between the end lines and the goal lines.

2.2.4. **No-Running Zones:** The no-running zones are the 5-yard areas at both ends of the field in front of the goal lines.

2.2.5. **Goal Lines:** Goal lines, one for each team, shall be established at opposite ends of the field of play. The goal lines and goal line pylons are in the end zone. Each goal line is part of a vertical plane which separates the end zone from the field of play and extends beyond the side lines. A team's goal line is the one it is defending.

2.2.6. **Middle Line:** Midway between the goal lines is the middle line. The middle of the middle line is the line to gain for a new series of downs and is hereafter called middle for short.

2.2.7. **In Bounds and Out of Bounds:** The area enclosed by the side lines and end lines is in bounds and everywhere else (including the side lines and end lines themselves) is out of bounds.

2.2.8. **Team Areas:** The team areas are outside the safety area (3 yards away from the side line) and between the 5-yard lines along the side line with a depth of 5 yards (4,58 m).

2.2.8.1. If there is a conflict with the safety area, then the team areas shall be moved elsewhere.

2.2.8.2. If, due to space limitations, it is necessary to relocate the team areas from their normal positions, both teams must be treated equally. The ground area for both teams must be approximately of the same size, they must be in close sight of the field and there must be a minimum distance of

2.2.8.3. 10 yards (9,15 m) between them.

2.2.8.4. When the team areas will be located on the same side of the field, both coaches of each team are allowed to work in their respective team area, as always, and use the safety area between their team area and the 5-yd line at the other end of the field.

2.2.8.5. When the team areas are located anywhere else, both coaches of each team may work anywhere along the sideline outside the safety area between the 5-yard lines on opposing sides of the field; or in case of not enough space it is also possible to allow the coaches to use the safety area on opposing sides.

2.2.8.6. The use of electronic devices (headsets, video recorders, smart phones etc.) in the team area is legal.

2.3. Team and Player Designations

2.3.1. **Offense (O) and Defense (D):** The offense is the team which puts the ball in play by a snap. The defense is the opposing team. A player of the offensive team is either a snapper, a runner or a receiver. A player of the defensive team is either a blitzer, rusher or defender.

2.3.2. **Snapper:** The snapper is the offensive player who snaps the ball.

2.3.3. **Quarterback:** The quarterback is the offensive player who first gets possession of the ball after the snap. They are also the first runner.

2.3.4. **Passer:** The passer is a runner who throws a legal pass.

2.3.5. **Runner:** The runner is a player in possession of a live ball.

2.3.6. **Blitzer:** A defender who lines up with all parts of their body more than 7 yards away from the scrimmage line at the snap can establish themselves as a blitzer with a legal signal by raising one hand clearly above the head at least during the last second prior to the snap. This grants them right of way which supersedes the general right of way for the offense, because they are pursuing the runner.

2.3.6.1. The rush of a blitzer shall be immediately after the snap, quick and straight towards the point where the quarterback receives the snap in order to retain the right of way.

2.3.6.2. If a blitzer is rushing late, slowly, towards a different spot, changing direction during the rush or just does not rush the quarterback, the player loses the right of way but still can participate as any other defender.

2.3.6.3. A defender who does not give a signal and legally crosses the scrimmage line is a rusher.

2.3.7. **All-Rounder (AR):** An All-Rounder (AR) is a player officially registered as eligible to play on both offense and defense.

2.3.7.1. Each team may register a maximum of six All-Rounders: three male and three female. A player's AR designation can only be added, removed or changed during an official transfer window.

2.3.7.2. Every AR must still have a registered primary position, such as Quarterback, Receiver, Defender or Rusher. Playing in that primary position does not activate the player's AR status.

2.3.7.3. For avoidance of doubt:

2.3.7.3.1. A registered Defender playing on defense does not count as an active AR.

2.3.7.3.2. A registered Receiver or Quarterback playing on offense does not count as an active AR.

2.3.7.3.3. A registered Defender who enters the offensive lineup counts as an active AR.

2.3.7.3.4. A registered Receiver or Quarterback who enters the defensive lineup counts as an active AR.

2.3.7.4. In simple terms, an AR only counts towards the on-field AR limit when the player crosses over from their registered primary unit to play on the opposite unit.

2.3.8. **Out of Bounds:** A player is out of bounds when any part of their body touches anything out of bounds except another player or official. The ball not in player possession is out of bounds when it touches anything out of bounds.

2.3.9. **Disqualified Player:** A disqualified player is one who has been declared ineligible from further participation in the game.

2.3.10. **Home Team:** The team identified as the home team on the official Showtime schedule shall be the home team. The other team shall be the visiting team. If the schedule does not designate a home team, the team listed first is the home team.

2.4. Down, Scrimmage and Play Classification

2.4.1. **Down:** A down is the part of the game that starts with a legal snap, or with the legal release of a declared punt throw, after the ball is ready for play and ends when the ball becomes dead. Between downs is the interval during which the ball is dead. A play is the action between the 2 teams during a down.

2.4.2. **Scrimmage Line (SL):** When the ball is made ready for play the scrimmage line for each team is the vertical plane that passes through the point of the ball closest to its own goal line and extends to the side lines. A player has crossed the scrimmage line if any part of the body has been beyond their respective scrimmage line.

2.4.3. **Forward Pass Play:** A legal forward pass play is the interval between the snap and when a legal forward pass beyond the scrimmage line is completed or intercepted. Also, any forward pass from behind the scrimmage line becoming incomplete or touched by the defense is considered as a forward pass play.

2.4.4. **Running Play:** A running play is any live ball action other than that during a legal forward pass play. Passes completed behind the scrimmage line are legal and are running plays.

2.5. The Ball Live or Dead

2.5.1. **Live Ball:** A live ball is a ball in play. A pass that has not yet touched the ground is a live ball in flight.

2.5.2. **Dead Ball:** A dead ball is a ball not in play.

2.5.3. **When Ball is Ready for Play:** A dead ball is ready for play when the ball is placed on the ground and the Referee blows the whistle.

2.6. Forward, Beyond and Forward Progress

2.6.1. **Forward and Beyond:** Forward, beyond or in advance of denotes the direction toward the opposing team's end line. Backward or behind denotes the direction towards a team's own end line.

2.6.2. **Forward Progress:** Forward progress is a term indicating the end of advancement by the runner or airborne pass receiver of either team and applies to the most forward point of the ball when it becomes dead by rule between the end lines (dead ball spot).

2.7. Spots

2.7.1. Enforcement Spot: An enforcement spot is the point from which the penalty for a foul is enforced.

2.7.2. Dead Ball Spot (DB): The dead ball spot is the point at which the ball becomes dead.

2.7.3. Spot of Foul (SF): The spot of the foul is the point at which that foul occurs. If out of bounds, it is the adjacent spot on the side line. If behind the goal line, the foul is in the end zone.

2.7.4. Out-of-Bounds Spot: The out-of-bounds spot is the point at which the ball becomes dead due to of being out of bounds.

2.8. Foul, Penalty and Violation

2.8.1. **Foul:** A foul is a rule infraction for which a penalty is prescribed by rule. A flagrant foul is a rule infraction that places an opponent in danger of injury.

2.8.2. **Penalty**: A penalty is a result imposed by rule against a team that has committed a foul and may include one or more of the following: loss of yardage, loss of down, or disqualification. If the penalty involves loss of a down, the down shall count as 1 of the 4 in that series.

2.8.3. **Violation:** A violation is a rule infraction for which no penalty is prescribed, it does not offset a foul.

2.8.4. **Loss of Down (LOD):** "Loss of Down" is an abbreviation meaning "loss of the right to repeat a down". A loss of down will be only applied if the foul is by the offense prior to a change of team possession.

2.8.5. **Automatic First Down (AFD):** "Automatic First Down" is an abbreviation meaning "award the offense a new series". An automatic first down will be only applied if the foul is by the defense prior to a change of team possession.

2.9. Shift and Motion

2.9.1. **Shift:** A shift is a simultaneous change of position by 2 or more offensive players after the ball is made ready for play and before the snap. The shift ends when all players have been stationary for 1 full second.

2.9.2. **Motion:** A motion is a change of position by one offensive player after the end of a shift and before the snap.

2.10. Handling of the Ball

2.10.1. **Hand-off:** A hand-off is a successful transfer of possession from one teammate to another that does not involve a pass. A fake hand-off is any movement of the runner with the hands towards a nearby teammate that simulates a transfer of possession. A

faked pass (pump or simulated pitch) or the runner turning the body towards a teammate without movement of the hands is not a fake hand-off.

2.10.2. **Pass:** A pass is any intentional act to throw the ball in any direction or drop it to the ground. A pass is identified by a period where the ball is not in any player's possession. A pass starts with the final release after firm control during an intentional movement of the hand or arm. A pass continues to be a pass until it is completed to a player or the ball becomes dead.

2.10.3. **Fumble:** A fumble is any act other than passing or successful handing that result in loss of player possession. A fumble can only occur after a player gains possession of a ball.

2.10.4. **Possession:** Possession means firmly holding or controlling a live ball. A change of team possession (COP) occurs when an opponent gains possession of the ball.

2.10.5. **Batting:** Batting the ball is intentionally striking it with the hands or arms.

2.10.6. **Kicking:** Kicking the ball is intentionally striking it with the knee, lower leg or foot and is illegal.

2.11. Passes

2.11.1. **Forward and Backward Pass:** A pass is forward if the ball first touches anything beyond the spot where the ball is released. All other passes are backward passes, even if it is lateral (parallel to the scrimmage line). A snap becomes a backward pass when the snapper releases the ball. If a snapper loses control of the ball as they begin the snap, it is an illegal snap.

2.11.2. **Crosses Scrimmage Line:** A legal forward pass has crossed the scrimmage line when it first touches anything beyond the scrimmage line in bounds.

2.11.3. **Catch and Interception:** A catch is the act of firmly establishing and maintaining control of a live ball in flight.

2.11.3.1. A catch of an opponent's pass or fumble is an interception.

2.11.3.2. A player who leaves the ground to make a catch or interception must have the ball firmly controlled when first returning to the ground with any part of the body touching the ground in bounds and then maintain complete and continuous control of the ball throughout the process of contacting the ground to complete the pass.

2.11.3.3. If the player loses control of the ball and the ball touches the ground before the process of the catch is completed then it is not a catch.

2.11.4. **Sack:** A sack is the removal of a flag (flag pull) from the quarterback behind the scrimmage line who is in possession of a live ball. A player is in possession of the ball until the ball is completely released.

2.12. Holding, Shielding, Contact and Aiming

2.12.1. **Holding:** Holding is grasping an opponent or their equipment, not releasing immediately and impacting the opponent.

2.12.2. **Shielding:** Shielding is obstructing an opponent without contact by moving into their path. A moving player without right of way who impedes an opponent from running a pass route, getting to the runner or impedes a legal blitzer is guilty of shielding.

2.12.3. A player standing still (with the right of place) is not shielding, even if the player is obstructing an opponent.

2.12.4. **Contact:** Contact is touching an opponent with impact. Touching with no impact is not a foul.

2.12.5. **Aiming:** Aiming is to target and initiate contact with an opponent or to run into an opponent, even with right of way. Aiming is any deliberate or avoidable contact with force against an opponent, even in an attempted flag pull or while playing the ball

during a pass. Aiming is to attack a ball in possession or take away the ball from the runner.

2.13. Flag Pulling, Flag Guarding, Jumping, Dipping, Spinning and Diving

2.13.1. **Flag Pull:** A flag pull is the removal of one or more flags from an opponent with one or more hands. The defender has the right to move towards the runner and attack the flags.

2.13.2. **Flag Guarding:** Flag guarding is an attempt by the runner to avoid a flag pull by covering the flag with any part of the body (hand, arm or leg) or with the ball or waving the hand below the hip in front of the flag before the flag pull attempt. Flag guarding is also stretching out a hand, with or without the ball, towards the opponent to make it more difficult for the defender to reach the flag.

2.13.3. **Jumping:** Jumping is an attempt by the runner to avoid a flag pull by pushing off the ground and thus raising the level of the flags significantly compared to regular running. Jumping is a type of flag guarding and illegal.

2.13.4. **Dipping:** Dipping is an attempt by the runner, with continuous movement, to avoid a flag pull by extra bending of the knees and lowering the level of the flags significantly compared to regular running. Dipping is legal.

2.13.5. **Spinning:** Spinning is an attempt by the runner to avoid a flag pull by rotation of the body along the vertical axis. Spinning is legal if the height of the flags is not significantly raised. Spinning combined with dipping is legal, combined with jumping or diving is illegal.

2.13.6. **Diving:** Diving is an attempt by the runner to avoid a flag pull or make the approach to the flag more difficult by leaning the upper body forward, with or without jumping, dipping or spinning. Diving is a type of flag guarding and is illegal.

2.14. Right of Place and Right of Way

2.14.1. **Right of Place (ROP):** Right of place is given to any stationary players who maintains normal player posture and make no movements in any horizontal direction to change their position. A purely vertical movement, including a lift from the ground, in order to throw or catch a pass does not mean that a previously established right of place has been lost. Right of place supersedes right of way when determining who is guilty of a foul.

2.14.2. **Female Player Right of Place**: a female player who has established a position shall have right of place against a male opponent. The female player retains this right of place while stationary, rooted in position or making a substantially vertical jump to catch, intercept, bat or otherwise play the ball. A vertical jump shall not be treated as surrendering her established position.

2.14.3. A male player approaching the same ball must avoid contact with the female player. He may not:

- **2.14.3.1.** Jump into, over or through her body or occupied vertical space;
- **2.14.3.2.** Displace her from an established position;
- **2.14.3.3.** Make contact with her while attempting to reach, catch, intercept or bat the ball;
- **2.14.3.4.** Prevent her from returning safely to the ground; or
- **2.14.3.5.** Land on, underneath or across her body.

2.14.4. The fact that both players are attempting to play the ball does not remove the male player's responsibility to avoid contact. Equal rights to the ball do not permit a male player to play through a female player who has established right of place.

2.14.5. This protection does not prevent a male player from playing the ball from an open or unoccupied path, provided he does so without contacting or endangering the female player.

2.14.6. A female player shall not rely on this protection to initiate contact, move laterally into an opponent's established path, or deliberately obstruct an opponent after that opponent has established right of place.

2.14.7. Any reckless or forceful contact that endangers the female player shall be treated as a flagrant foul and may result in disqualification and further disciplinary action.

> **PENALTY - Illegal Contact: Ball on the spot of the foul or 10 yards from the line of scrimmage.**

2.14.8. **Right of Way (ROW):** Right of way is given to a player according to rule who has established a direction of movement in a regular manner and does not alter that direction. A player with right of way has a higher privilege when determining who is guilty of a foul than all other players except those with right of place.

3.0. Periods and Timing

3.1. Start of Each Period

3.1.1. **Opening Throw-Off:** Three minutes before the scheduled start, the Referee shall conduct a coin toss at midfield in the presence of both captains. The winner shall choose either to make or receive the opening throw-off, or which end to defend. The opposing team shall exercise the remaining choice. The game begins with a throw-off.

3.1.2. **Second Half:** In the second half, the teams shall defend the opposite goal lines. The team that made the opening throw-off shall put the ball in play by receiving the second half throw-off, unless the Season Competition Regulations provide for another restart.

3.1.3. **Overtime (Tie Breaker):** The tiebreaker system shall be used when a game is tied after 2 halves and the competition mandates a winner needs to be determined.

3.1.3.1. After a 2 minute intermission, the Referee shall toss a coin at midfield as at the beginning of the game. The winner of the coin toss will choose to start each following period on offense or defense. The other team will elect which end of the field will be used.

3.1.3.2. No charged team timeouts shall be granted.

3.1.3.3. The first extra period shall consist of 2 series with each team putting the ball in play by a snap at the middle line for one series of downs (no first down at middle). Should the defense score during the first series, other than on the try, then the extra period is over.

3.1.3.4. Each team retains the ball during its series until it scores (including try downs for 1 or 2 points) or exhausts its series of downs. The ball remains alive after a change of team possession until it is declared dead. The series is then ended even if there is a second change of team possession during that down.

3.1.3.5. If after the first period (with 2 series including tries) the score is still tied, the second and following periods consist of series with each team playing a 1-point try from the 5-yard line. The overtime ends when the score after a period is no longer a tie or the defense scores during the first series of a period.

3.1.3.6. The team scoring the greater number of points during overtime shall be declared the winner.

3.1.3.7. In a two-leg round, overtime would apply only if the scores are tied after the second leg of play.

3.2. Playing Time

3.2.1. **Length of Play and Intermission:** The total playing time shall be 50 minutes, divided into 2 halves of 25 minutes each, with a 5 minute intermission between halves.

3.2.2. **Extension of Periods:** A period shall be extended until a down has been played which is free from live ball fouls (without loss of down) for which the penalty is accepted. If offsetting fouls occur during a down in which time expires, the down will be repeated. No period shall end until the ball is dead and the Referee declares the period ended.

3.2.3. **Timing Devices:** The game clock and the 25-second-clock shall be kept by either a stopwatch operated by an official or by a visible clock operated by an assistant under the direction of the appropriate official.

3.2.4. **When Clock Starts:** When the game clock has been stopped by rule it shall be started when the ball is next legally snapped.

3.2.5. **When Clock Stops:** The game clock shall be stopped when each half ends, for a charged team timeout, for an injury timeout or at the Referee's discretion. Within the last 1 minutes of each half the clock shall stop:

3.2.5.1. To award a first down, also after a change of team possession.
3.2.5.2. To complete a penalty.
3.2.5.3. When the ball or the runner goes out of bounds.
3.2.5.4. When a pass or fumble (forward or backward) strikes the ground.
3.2.5.5. When a teammate of the fumbler touches the ball.
3.2.5.6. When a score is made and during and after the following try.
3.2.5.7. When a charged timeout is granted.
3.2.5.8. The game clock shall not run during an extension of a half or overtime.

3.2.6. **Running Clock**

3.2.6.1. If the score difference is 30 points or more at the Referee's notification, the clock will not stop for situations it normally would do so for in the last 1 minutes.
3.2.6.2. The Referee will inform both teams at the Referee's notification that the clock will no longer be stopped (running clock) for the remainder of the half.
3.2.6.3. After the Referee's notification, the established status of the clock (standard timing or running clock) will not change even if the score difference goes below 30 or reaches 30 or more points.

3.3. Timeouts

3.3.1. **How Charged:** The Referee shall declare a timeout when the game is suspended for any reason. Each timeout shall be charged to one of the teams or designated as an official timeout. The Referee shall call an official timeout if discussion of the ruling or other circumstances, take a significant amount of time.

3.3.2. **Charged Team Timeouts:** An official shall allow a charged team timeout when requested by any coach or inbound player when the ball is dead. Each team is entitled to 3 charged team timeouts per half. Unused timeouts may not be carried over to a subsequent period.

3.3.3. **Injury Timeout:** In the event of an injured player any official may declare an official timeout, provided the player for whom the timeout is taken is removed from the game for at least one down.

3.3.4. **Length of Timeouts**

3.3.4.1. A charged team timeout shall not exceed 30 seconds.
3.3.4.2. The Referee can shorten any charged timeout by agreement of both teams.
3.3.4.3. Other timeouts shall be no longer than the Referee deems necessary to fulfill the purpose for which they are declared.
3.3.4.4. The Referee shall notify both teams when any timeout has expired and 5 seconds later shall declare the ball ready for play.

3.3.5. **Referee's Notification:** The Referee shall inform all coaches when 1 minutes or less of playing time remain in a half and the ball is or becomes dead next. The game clock shall be stopped for this purpose.

4.0. Live Ball and Dead Ball

4.1. Live Ball - Dead Ball

4.1.1. **Dead Ball becomes Alive:** For the next down the ball shall be put in play at the spot midway between the side lines, laterally in line with the spot where the ball was when it became dead by rule, or at the spot where the ball has been placed following completion of an accepted penalty or to award a new series.

4.1.2. After a dead ball is made ready for play it becomes a live ball with the start of a legal snap, the legal release of a throw-off or the legal release of a declared punt throw. A ball put in play before it is made ready for play, or put in play illegally, remains dead.

4.1.3. A foul before the ball is snapped (delay of game, encroachment, false start, disconcerting signal, illegal blitzer signal) will cause the ball to remain dead.

4.1.4. **Live Ball becomes Dead:** A live ball becomes dead by rule and an official shall sound a whistle when:

- **4.1.4.1.** The ball is out of bounds.
- **4.1.4.2.** The runner is out of bounds.
- **4.1.4.3.** Any part of the runner's body except their hand or foot touches the ground.
- **4.1.4.4.** A runner simulates placing the knee on the ground.
- **4.1.4.5.** A pass or fumble (forward or backward) strikes the ground.
- **4.1.4.6.** A teammate of the fumbler touches the ball.
- **4.1.4.7.** A player with fewer than 2 flags is in possession of the ball.
- **4.1.4.8.** A player with flags not positioned correctly is in possession of the ball and the player themselves is responsible.
- **4.1.4.9.** A touchdown, touchback, safety or successful try occurs.
- **4.1.4.10.** A foul which causes the ball to become dead (e.g. illegal kick or delay of pass) occurs.

4.1.5. On an inadvertent whistle by an official, the ball becomes dead and the team in possession may elect either to put the ball next in play where it was declared dead or to replay the down.

5.0. Series of Downs

5.1. A Series: Started, Broken, Renewed

5.1.1. **When to Award Series:** A series of 4 consecutive scrimmage downs shall be awarded to the team entitled to possession after the opening throw-off, after a score (including try), safety, touchback, change of team possession or punt throw. Except where these rules provide for a throw-off or punt throw, the series begins with a snap.

5.1.2. A new series shall be awarded to the offense if:

5.1.2.1. It is in legal possession (following the application of any accepted live ball penalty) of the ball beyond the middle when the ball is declared dead and it is the first time in this series that has happened. If a subsequent play or penalty brings the ball back behind the middle and the ball is then advanced across the middle line for a second time during the same series, no new first down shall be awarded.

5.1.2.2. An accepted penalty results in or mandates a first down.

5.1.3. A new series shall be awarded to the defense on its own 5-yard line if the offense following 4th down has failed to score or earn a new first down.

5.1.4. A new series shall be awarded to the defense at the dead ball spot after an interception.

5.2. Down and Possession after a Penalty

5.2.1. **Foul Before Change of Team Possession:** If a penalty is accepted for a foul that occurred during a down before any change of team possession, the ball belongs to the offense and the down shall be repeated, unless the penalty involves loss of a down, mandates a first down or leaves the ball beyond the middle.

5.2.2. **Foul After Change of Team Possession:** If a penalty is accepted for a foul that occurred during a down after change of team possession, the ball belongs to the team in possession when the foul occurred. The next down shall be a first down after enforcement of the penalty.

5.2.3. **Penalty Declined:** If a penalty is declined, the number of the next down shall be whatever it would have been if that foul had not occurred.

5.2.4. **Foul Between Downs:** If a foul occurs between downs, the number of the next down shall be the same as that established before the foul occurred, unless enforcement of the penalty leaves the ball beyond the middle or the penalty mandates a first down.

5.2.5. **Fouls by Both Teams:** If offsetting fouls occur during a down, the previous down shall be repeated.

6.0. Throw-Offs, Punt Throws and Illegal Kicks

6.1. Throw-Off

6.1.1. **When Used:** A throw-off is the Showtime procedure used to put the ball in play at the beginning of a half. It is executed by throwing, not kicking, the ball from the designated throw-off line. Additional throw-offs may be used where stated in the Season Competition Regulations.

6.1.2. **Live Ball and Possession:** The throw-off becomes live when legally released.

- **6.1.2.1.** The throwing team may not interfere with the throw until the ball is caught or dead.
- **6.1.2.2.** If the throw is caught inside the throw-off zone, the team may choose to return or take a knee and spot the ball at the 10-yard line. A player cannot take the knee after they have moved from their position.
- **6.1.2.3.** If the ball lands in the throw-off zone without a catch, the ball is spotted at the higher of the landing or 10-yard line.
- **6.1.2.4.** The throw-off zone is the full-length of the yard marker from the endzone line.
- **6.1.2.5.** If the ball lands in the safe zone, the ball will be spotted at the first point of ball landing unless caught and returned further.
- **6.1.2.6.** If the ball lands in the endzone, it will be spotted at the 10-yard line unless caught and returned. Once a ball is caught, getting sacked in the endzone will result in a safety score by the throwing team.
- **6.1.2.7.** If the ball is caught in the endzone, it must be advanced or returned. If the flag of the receiving player is pulled in the endzone, the ball shall be deemed Safety.
- **6.1.2.8.** There can be no laterals once the ball is caught.
- **6.1.2.9.** If the receiving team player fumbles the ball, the throwing team may catch the fumbled ball (as long as the ball is not dead) and advance to the goal line.
- **6.1.2.10.** If a receiving-team player catches a throw-off in their own end zone, the player must return the ball into the field of play. If the player falls, slips, takes a knee, is deflagged or otherwise causes the ball to become dead while still in possession inside the end zone, a safety shall be awarded to the throwing team. A caught throw-off shall not result in a touchback.

6.1.3. **Defending a Throw-Off**

- **6.1.3.1.** The throwing team shall line up on the halfway line. And can only move after the ball is released.
- **6.1.3.2.** Moving early grants the throwing team a 5 yard penalty from wherever the ball lands.

6.2. Punt Throw

6.2.1. **Eligibility to Punt:** A team may elect to punt only on fourth down.

- **6.2.1.1.** A team may punt only when the ball is in its own territory and the team has not crossed the half-field line at any time during the current possession.
- **6.2.1.2.** The punt shall be made from the spot of the preceding down.

6.2.2. **Declaration of Punt:** The captain or head coach of the punting team must declare the decision to punt to the Referee before the ready-for-play whistle.

- **6.2.2.1.** After the punt is declared, the defensive team must be allowed at least five seconds to set its formation before the ball is made ready for play.
- **6.2.2.2.** Once declared, the punt remains subject to the fake-punt provisions contained in Article 5.

6.2.3. Punter and Snapper

6.2.3.1. The player acting as the punter may not be the team's designated quarterback.

6.2.3.2. The centre must remain at the snap spot after delivering the ball and may not move from that position until the punt is released or the play becomes a fake punt.

6.2.3.3. Any movement or action by the centre intended to obstruct, screen or impede a defensive player constitutes illegal interference.

6.2.3.4. If a receiving-team player catches a punt throw in their own end zone, the player must return the ball into the field of play. If the player falls, slips, takes a knee, is deflagged or otherwise causes the ball to become dead while still in possession inside the end zone, a safety shall be awarded to the punting team. A caught punt throw shall not result in a touchback.

6.2.4. Defensive Formation and Rush

6.2.4.1. he defensive team may use any legal formation of its choice.

6.2.4.2. The defensive team may designate up to three rushers.

6.2.4.3. If the punter's flag is legally pulled before the punt is released, the punter is considered sacked. The ball becomes dead immediately and possession passes to the defensive team at the spot of the sack.

6.2.4.4. Deliberately running into a stationary centre during a declared punt is a flagrant foul. The following sanctions apply:

6.2.4.4.1. Illegal contact penalty

6.2.4.4.2. The offending rusher is ejected from the game; and

6.2.4.4.3. The offending rusher is automatically suspended for the team's next two games.

6.2.5. Punt Timing and Fake Punt

6.2.5.1. The punter has seven seconds from the completion of the snap to release the punt.

6.2.5.2. The punt begins when the ball is released by the punter and not when the ball is snapped.

6.2.5.3. The punter may abandon the punt and attempt to run or otherwise make a normal fourth-down play. The play will then be treated as a fake punt.

6.2.5.4. Any punting-team player who leaves their set position after the snap but before the ball is released converts the play into a fake punt. The normal movements required to complete the snap, receive the ball and release the punt do not, by themselves, constitute a fake punt.

6.2.5.5. Once the play becomes a fake punt, all rules governing a normal fourth-down scrimmage play apply.

6.2.5.6. If the punter neither releases the punt nor begins a legal fake-punt play before the seven-second period expires, the ball becomes dead and possession passes to the defensive team at the previous spot.

6.2.6. Possession Following a Punt

6.2.6.1. A punt that is caught and returned results in the receiving team beginning its offensive possession on second down.

6.2.6.2. A punt that is not caught results in the receiving team beginning its offensive possession on first down.

6.2.6.3. No backward pass or lateral is permitted during a punt return unless the resulting play is a fake punt.

6.3. Illegal Kicking

6.3.1. **Illegal Kick:** The runner may not intentionally kick the ball. This foul causes the ball to become dead.

PENALTY - 5 yards, spot of foul is the scrimmage line, enforced from the scrimmage line.

7.0. Snapping and Passing the Ball

7.1. The Scrimmage

7.1.1. **Ball Ready for Play:** No player shall put the ball in play before it is ready for play. The ball shall be put in play within 15 seconds after the Referee has declared the ball ready for play.

7.1.2. **Starting with a Snap:** After the snapper touches the ball, the snapper may not lift the ball, move it forward or simulate the start of the snap.

7.1.2.1. Before the snap, the long axis of the ball shall be at right angles to the scrimmage line.

7.1.2.2. A legal snap is handing or passing the ball backward from its position on the ground with a quick and continuous backward motion of the hand or hands that results in losing possession of the ball. The snap need not be between the snapper's legs.

7.1.2.3. A snap is legal if it is a backward pass in any direction.

7.1.3. **Offensive Team Requirements:** There is no minimum number of players on the scrimmage line at the snap.

7.1.3.1. After the snapper touches the ball and before the ball is snapped all offensive players shall be in bounds behind their scrimmage line (encroachment).

7.1.3.2. The first and each following shift must be completed before the snap starts.

7.1.3.3. No offensive player shall make a false start or make any abrupt movement that simulates the beginning of a play.

PENALTY - Ball remains dead, 5 yards, enforced from the dead ball spot.

7.1.3.4. When the snap starts, one offensive player may be in motion, may not be moving toward the opponent's goal line. When the snap starts and 2 or more players are moving, it is an illegal shift.

7.1.3.5. The quarterback cannot run with the ball beyond the scrimmage line, unless the ball has been solely possessed by another player and returned to them or touched by a defender while in flight.

PENALTY - 5 yards, enforced from the scrimmage line.

7.1.3.6. When the ball is snapped on or inside the 5-yard line going towards the opponent's end zone (no-running zone), the offense shall make a forward pass play. If the quarterback or runner gets deflagged behind the scrimmage line before a forward pass play has been completed, there is no foul for an illegal run play.

PENALTY - 5 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the scrimmage line.

7.1.3.7. The quarterback has 7 seconds to pass or hand-off the ball after the snap. If this limit is exceeded, the ball becomes dead at the scrimmage line.

PENALTY - Loss of down at the scrimmage line

7.1.4. **Defensive Team Requirements**

7.1.4.1. Before the ball is snapped all defenders shall be in bounds and behind their scrimmage line (offside).

7.1.4.2. After the ball is declared ready for play no defender shall touch the ball until after the snap is complete.

7.1.4.3. No defender shall use words or signals that disconcert opponents when they are preparing to put the ball in play.

7.1.4.4. A maximum of 3 players may establish themselves as a blitzer. If a player who signals is less than 7 yards from the scrimmage line or if a player is giving an invalid signal or if more than 2 players simultaneously keep their hand raised after the snapper has touched the ball, it is a foul for illegal signal.

PENALTY - Ball remains dead, 5 yards, enforced from the dead ball spot.

7.1.4.5. Any defender who has all parts of the body more than 7 yards away from the scrimmage line at the snap may cross the scrimmage line multiple times until the ball is dead. There is no requirement for a player requesting right of way to establish as blitzer and any player (> 7 yards) may rush the quarterback during the play.

7.1.4.6. All defenders less than 7 yards away from their scrimmage line at the snap shall stay behind their scrimmage line until the ball has been handed off, fake handed off or passed by the quarterback.

PENALTY - 5 yards, spot of foul is the scrimmage line, enforced from the scrimmage line.

7.1.5. **Handing the Ball:** The offense may hand off the ball multiple times as long as both involved players are behind the scrimmage line, provided the ball has not been carried beyond the scrimmage line and it is prior to any change of team possession. No snapper shall receive a forward hand-off.

PENALTY - 5 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the spot of foul.

7.2. Passes and Fumbles

7.2.1. **Backward Pass:** A runner may pass the ball backwards provided it has not previously been carried beyond the scrimmage line and it is prior to any change of team possession.

PENALTY - 5 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the spot of foul.

7.2.2. **Complete Pass:** Any pass caught by an eligible player touching the ground in bounds is completed and the ball continues in play unless completed in the opponent's end zone.

7.2.3. **Incomplete Pass:** Any pass is incomplete if the ball touches the ground when not firmly controlled by a player. It also is incomplete when a player jumps and receives the pass but first lands on or outside a boundary line.

7.2.3.1. When a forward pass is incomplete, the ball belongs to the passing team at the previous scrimmage line, which is the dead ball spot.

7.2.3.2. When a backward pass is incomplete, the ball belongs to the passing team at the spot of the last player's possession, which is the dead ball spot.

7.2.4. **Fumble:** When a fumble hits the ground or is touched by a teammate of the runner (fumbler) without being touched by an opponent before, the ball is dead and belongs to the fumbling team at the spot where the fumbler lost possession, this is the dead ball spot. If the fumbler or an opponent gains possession before the ball becomes dead, the ball continues in play.

7.2.5. **Illegal Touching and Batting:** The passer is only allowed to touch, bat or catch a pass that has been thrown by themselves after it has been touched by a defender. No offensive player who goes out of bounds voluntarily during a down shall touch a pass in flight. If an offensive player is forced out of bounds due to a foul and immediately

returns to the field of play or end zone, the player remains eligible to touch or catch a pass.

PENALTY - Loss of down at the scrimmage line.

7.2.5.1. A backward pass shall not be batted forward by the passing team.

7.2.6. Outside of the above restriction, inbound players are eligible to touch or bat a pass in any direction.

PENALTY - 5 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the spot of foul.

7.3. Forward Pass

7.3.1. **Legal Forward Pass:** A team may make one forward pass during each scrimmage down before team possession changes, provided the pass is thrown from a point behind the scrimmage line.

7.3.2. **Illegal Forward Pass:** A forward pass is illegal:

7.3.2.1. If thrown by an offensive player who is beyond the scrimmage line when the ball is released.

7.3.2.2. If thrown after a runner has gone beyond the scrimmage line.

7.3.2.3. If it is the second forward pass by the offense during the same down.

7.3.2.4. If thrown after team possession has changed during the down.

PENALTY - Loss of down, enforced from the line of scrimmage.

7.3.3. **Pass Interference:** Pass interference is physical contact on a legal forward pass play up to the point where the pass is touched by a player or falls incomplete.

7.3.3.1. Pass interference is contact that interferes with an opponent whilst the ball is in the air. It is the responsibility of the defender to avoid the opponents.

7.3.3.2. It is not pass interference when 2 or more eligible players are making a simultaneous and fair attempt to touch, bat or catch the pass. Eligible players of either team have equal rights to the ball, but it is the responsibility of the player in the disadvantageous position to avoid the opponent.

7.3.3.3. Contact on a pass play before the pass has been thrown or if the pass does not cross the scrimmage line, is a foul for illegal contact

PENALTY - Ball on the spot of the foul or 10 yards, enforced from the line of scrimmage. Loss of down for fouls by offense.

7.4. Female-Quarterback Down

7.4.1. **Third Down:** Every third down is a female-only down.

7.4.1.1. All offensive and defensive players participating in the down must be female. No male player may remain on the field, enter the field or participate in the play after the ball is made ready for play.

7.4.1.2. The offensive snap must be received by an eligible female quarterback. Any forward pass during the down must be thrown by that quarterback.

7.4.1.3. The approved female-designated ball must be used throughout the down.

7.4.1.4. The participation of a male player, the use of an ineligible quarterback or the use of an unapproved ball constitutes illegal participation.

PENALTY - 5 yards, enforced from the scrimmage line.

8.0. Scoring

8.1. Value of Scores

8.1.1. **Scoring Plays – Offense:** The point value of scoring plays shall be:

Formation	Passer	Receiver	Point(s)
1st, 2nd and 4th downs	Male	Male	6
	Male	Female	7
	Female	Female	9
	Female	Male	8
3rd Down Female	Female	Female	6
Extra Point [10 yards from goal]	Male	Male	1
	Male	Female	2
	Female	Male	2
	Female	Female	3

8.1.2. **Scoring Plays – Defense:** The point value of scoring defensive plays shall be:

Formation	Passer	Defender	Point(s)
1st, 2nd and 4th downs	Male	Male	6
	Male	Female	7
	Female	Female	9
	Female	Male	8
3rd Down Female	Female	Female	6
Extra Point [10 yards from goal]	Male	Male	1
	Male	Female	2
	Female	Male	1
	Female	Female	2

8.2. Touchdown

8.2.1. **How Scored:** A touchdown shall be scored when:

8.2.1.1. The ball in possession of a runner advancing from the field of play penetrates the plane of the opponent's goal line.

8.2.1.2. A player catches a pass in the opponent's end zone.

8.3. Try Down

8.3.1. **How Scored:** The points shall be scored according to the point values if the try results in what would be a touchdown or safety.

8.3.2. **Opportunity to Score:** A try is an extra down with the opportunity for either team to score 1 or 2 points.

8.3.2.1. The ball shall be put in play by the team that scored a 6-point touchdown. If a touchdown is scored during a down in which time expires the try shall be attempted. The scoring team shall decide to go for 1 or 2 points prior to the ball being declared ready for the try.

8.3.2.2. The try begins when the ball is made ready for play.

8.3.2.3. The snap shall be midway between the side lines on the opponent's 5-yard line (1 point) or 10-yard line (2 points).

8.3.2.4. The try ends when either team scores or the ball becomes dead by rule.

8.3.2.5. Accepted penalties will require either repeating the try or the try results in a score or the end of the try. If the try will be repeated after a penalty, it is still worth the same value as before. No change of decision (1 or 2 points) is possible before the try ends.

8.3.3. **Next Play:** After a try, the ball shall be put in play by the opponent on its own 5-yard line, if no penalty will be enforced.

8.4. Safety

8.4.1. **How Scored:** It is a safety when:

8.4.1.1. The ball becomes dead with any part on or behind the goal line, except for an incomplete pass or fumble from outside the end zone, and the team defending this goal line is responsible for the ball being there.

8.4.1.2. An accepted penalty for a foul leaves the ball on or behind the offending team's goal line.

8.4.2. **Snap After a Safety:** After a safety, the ball shall be put in play by the scoring team at its own 5-yard line.

8.5. Touchback

8.5.1. **When Declared:** It is a touchback when:

8.5.1.1. The ball becomes dead with any part on or behind the goal line, except for an incomplete pass or fumble from outside the end zone, and the team attacking this goal line is responsible for the ball being there.

8.5.1.2. A defender intercepts a pass between the own 5-yard line and their goal line and their original momentum carries the player into the end zone and the ball remains in the end zone where it becomes dead.

8.5.2. **Snap After a Touchback:** After a touchback, the ball shall be put in play by the defending team at its own 5-yard line.

9.0. Conduct of Players

9.1. Contact Fouls

9.1.1. Illegal Contact (IC)

9.1.1.1. No player shall intentionally contact an opponent or an official.

9.1.1.2. No player shall step, jump or stand on another player.

9.1.1.3. No player shall hold another player.

9.1.1.4. All stationary players have the right of place and opponents shall avoid contact.

9.1.1.5. The runner has no right of way and is fully charged with avoiding contact with opponents. If runner and defender contribute equally to the contact, the foul is by the offense.

9.1.1.6. All offensive players have the right of way as long as a legal forward pass is still possible and defenders shall avoid contact. When the forward pass is in the air all players have the right to play the ball, but not by aiming (playing through) an opponent. If receiver and defender contribute equally to an illegal contact, the foul is by the defense.

9.1.1.7. All blitzers rushing according the rule have the right of way and offensive players shall avoid contact.

9.1.1.8. No player shall commit aiming.

> **PENALTY – Ball on the spot of the foul or 10 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the line of scrimmage.**

9.1.2. Game Interference

No substitute or coach shall contact or interfere in any way with the ball, a player or an official during the game.

> **PENALTY - Ball on the spot of the foul or 10 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the line of scrimmage.**

9.2. Non-Contact Fouls

9.2.1. Unsportsmanlike Acts: Use of abusive, threatening or obscene language or gestures, or engaging in such acts that provoke ill will or are demeaning.

9.2.1.1. If a player is neither returning the ball to the next spot nor leaving it near the dead ball spot.

9.2.1.2. If a player is neither immediately returning a pulled flag to the opponent nor leaving it near the spot where it has been pulled. It is preferable for players to return the flag to the opponent.

> **PENALTY - 10 yards, enforced from the line of scrimmage or ball on the spot of the foul, administered as a dead ball foul.**

9.2.2. Unfair Acts

9.2.2.1. No player shall shield an opponent.

> **PENALTY - 5 yards, enforced from the basic spot.**

9.2.2.2. Diving or jumping is permitted and shall not, by itself, result in a penalty. However, a player who dives or jumps is responsible for avoiding contact with an opponent. If the diving or jumping action results in contact with an opponent, the player shall be penalized for Unnecessary Roughness.

> **PENALTY - 5 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the spot of foul.**

9.2.2.3. No runner shall commit flag guarding.

PENALTY - 5 yards, also loss of down, enforced from the spot of foul.

9.2.2.4. No player shall pull a flag from an opponent other than the runner, an opponent who simulates being the runner or when an opponent has touched the ball in flight.

PENALTY - 5 yards, enforced from the basic spot.

9.2.2.5. No player shall intentionally kick a pass or a fumble. This foul does not change the status of the ball, except if a teammate of the fumbler kicks the ball.

PENALTY - 5 yards, enforced from the basic spot.

9.2.2.6. Participation by more players than the applicable match format permits is illegal. The maximum is 5 players per team in 5v5 and 7 players per team in 7v7.

PENALTY - 5 yards, spot of foul is the scrimmage line, enforced from the scrimmage line.

9.2.2.7. Coaches and substitutes may not be outside the team area during a down.

PENALTY - 5 yards, spot of foul is the scrimmage line, enforced from the scrimmage line.

9.2.2.8. No player wearing illegal equipment or missing mandatory equipment shall be permitted to play.

9.2.2.9. A player with a bleeding wound shall leave the field.

9.2.2.10. Players shall leave the field immediately after being ordered to do so by an official.

VIOLATION - Charged timeout for the offending team.

PENALTY - 5 yards, if no timeouts remain.

9.3. Substitutions

9.3.1. **Substitution Procedures:** Any number of legal substitutes may enter the game to replace teammates after the ball is dead. The offense may substitute until the snapper touches the ball. The defense may substitute until the ball is snapped.

9.3.1.1. After the ball has been snapped, no substitute from either team shall enter the field of play.

PENALTY - 5 yards, spot of foul is the scrimmage line, enforced from the scrimmage line.

9.3.1.2. No offensive player shall enter or leave the field of play after the snapper has touched the ball.

9.3.1.3. No simulated replacements or substitutions may be used to confuse opponents. No tactic associated with substitutes or the substitution process may be used to confuse opponents.

PENALTY - Ball remains dead, 5 yards, enforced from the scrimmage line.

10.0. Penalty Enforcement

10.1. General

10.1.1. **Flagrant Fouls:** A flagrant foul is one which puts an opponent in danger of serious injury or one which is contrary to the principle of sportsmanship. Flagrant fouls require disqualification. Any player or coach who commits two unsportsmanlike acts during the same game shall be disqualified. A disqualified player or coach must leave the team area and remain out of view of the field. Any further sanction shall be determined under the Showtime Code of Conduct and disciplinary procedures.

10.1.2. **Unfair Tactics:** If a team refuses to play or repeatedly commits fouls that can be penalized only by halving the distance or commits an obviously unfair act not specifically covered by the rules, the Referee may take any action considered equitable, including assessing a penalty, disqualifying a player or coach, ordering a loss of down, awarding a first down to either team, awarding a score or suspending or forfeiting the game.

> *NOTE: The Referee should, but need not, warn the team and inform them that the foul will be called if they continue to repeat a certain unfair situation. It needs a lot of experience to find the appropriate judgment for when the Referee should make use of this rule. Officials should confer prior to any announcement by the Referee in order to ensure that the action being taken is appropriate.*

10.2. Penalties Completed

10.2.1. **How and when Completed:** A penalty is completed when it is accepted, declined or canceled.

10.2.1.1. Any penalty may be declined by a team of the non-offending team, but a disqualified player must leave the game.

10.2.1.2. When a foul is committed, the penalty shall be completed before the ball is declared ready for play for the next down.

10.2.2. **Simultaneous with Snap:** A foul that occurs simultaneously with the snap is considered as occurring during that down. The spot of foul is the scrimmage line.

10.2.3. **Live Ball Fouls by the Same Team:** When 2 or more live ball fouls by the same team are reported, the Referee shall explain the alternative penalties to the non-offending team, which then may elect one of these penalties to be enforced.

10.2.4. **Offsetting Fouls:** If live ball fouls by both teams are reported, the fouls offset and the down is replayed with the following exceptions:

10.2.4.1. When there is a change of team possession during a down and the team last gaining possession had not fouled before last gaining possession, it may decline offsetting fouls and thereby retain possession after completion of the penalty for its foul.

10.2.4.2. When a live ball foul is administered as a dead ball foul it does not offset and is enforced in order of occurrence.

10.2.5. **Dead Ball Fouls:** Penalties for dead ball fouls are administered separately and in order of occurrence. Dead ball fouls by both teams simultaneously will offset and the previous down counts.

10.2.6. **Interval Fouls:** Penalties for fouls that occur between periods are enforced from the start of the next series.

10.3. Enforcement Procedures

10.3.1. **Basic Spot (BS):** The basic spot is the scrimmage line with the following exceptions:

10.3.1.1. For offense fouls behind the scrimmage line, the basic spot is the spot of foul.

10.3.1.2. For defense fouls when the dead ball spot is beyond the scrimmage line, the basic spot is the dead ball spot.

10.3.1.3. For fouls after a change of team possession the basic spot will be the dead ball spot. If the foul is on the last related run from the team ending up in possession and the foul is behind the dead ball spot, the basic spot is the spot of foul.

10.3.1.4. For fouls after a change of team possession, committed by a team in their own end zone, before the ball is brought out of this end zone, the enforcement spot is the Touchback spot (own 5-yard line).

10.3.2. **Procedures:** The enforcement spot for live ball fouls is the previous scrimmage line if not otherwise stated in the penalty. The enforcement spot for dead ball fouls is the next scrimmage line. Fouls during or after a touchdown or try:

10.3.2.1. Fouls with a 10-yard penalty by the non-scoring team during a touchdown are enforced on the try. Other fouls by the non-scoring team are declined by rule.

10.3.2.2. Fouls after a touchdown and before the ball is ready for play on the try are enforced on the try.

10.3.2.3. Fouls with a 10-yard penalty by the non-scoring team during a successful try are enforced on the next new series. Other fouls by the non-scoring team are declined by rule.

10.3.2.4. Fouls with a 10-yard penalty by the non-scoring team after a change of team possession during a try will be enforced on the next new series. Other fouls are declined by rule.

10.3.2.5. Fouls after a try are enforced on the next new series.

10.3.3. **Half-Distance Enforcement:** No distance penalty, including tries, shall exceed half the distance from the enforcement spot to the offending team's goal line.

11.0. Officials and Match Authority

11.1. Appointment and Jurisdiction

11.1.1. **Appointment:** Showtime Football Operations shall appoint two or more officials for each match and designate the Referee. The number and positions of officials may be adjusted to the competition and venue.

11.1.2. **Jurisdiction:** The officials' jurisdiction begins with the coin toss and ends when the Referee declares the final score. Each official has responsibility and jurisdiction in matters of judgment, subject to the Referee's final authority over the match.

11.1.3. **Responsibilities:** Officials shall enforce these rules, record the score, administer the game clock and play clock, manage downs and possession, report disqualifications and complete any required match report. Detailed mechanics, positions, signals and uniforms are governed by the Showtime Officials Manual.

12.0. Challenges

12.1. Conference

12.1.1. **Requesting a Challenge:** Once in each half and once during overtime, a team may use a timeout to request a conference concerning the application of a rule or penalty enforcement. Judgment calls are not challengeable. The request must be made before the next legal snap or before the Referee's whistle for start of next play.

12.1.2. A challenge may only be made about the misapplication of a rule or incorrect penalty enforcement. Judgment calls are not challengeable. Another challenge on the same play by either team for the same reason cannot be requested.

12.1.3. After a team has requested a challenge the Referee will call an officials' timeout. The requesting team explains to the Referee, in the presence of a second official, what exactly they are challenging and the reason for it. The Head Referee will inform decide if the challenge is permitted by rule. The second official will inform the opposing team about the subject of a permitted challenge and the relevant members of the officiating crew will meet away from both teams.

12.1.4. The Referee will then explain and discuss the challenged ruling or enforcement with the video assistant referee. The Referee can request more information from the challenging team if needed for a decision.

12.1.5. All involved officials shall provide information carefully and faithfully in order to decide if the ruling/enforcement on the field was correct or if something was missed by the officials and it should be changed.

12.1.6. When this decision has been made, the Referee, accompanied by another official, will explain to the challenging team why the ruling/enforcement has or has not been changed and provide all relevant information regarding the status of the game (spot, down, time) to them. This information will then also be given to the opposing team.

12.1.7. **Timeout:** If the challenge is permitted and the ruling is altered, the requesting team will not be charged with a timeout and the game will continue.

12.1.8. If the challenge is not permitted or the ruling is not altered, the requesting team will be charged with a timeout and granted the full time allowed for this.

12.1.9. If the team has no timeouts remaining or the game is in overtime, it is a violation and no challenge will be granted.

> **VIOLATION - Charged timeout for the requesting team.**
>
> **PENALTY - 5 yards, if no timeouts remain.**

13.0. Summary of Penalties

13.1. LOSS OF 10 YARDS with LOD or AFD
- **13.1.1.** Pass interference
- **13.1.2.** Illegal contact
- **13.1.3.** Game interference

13.2. LOSS OF 10 YARDS
- **13.2.1.** Unsportsmanlike acts

13.3. LOSS OF 5 YARDS with LOD
- **13.3.1.** Illegal kick by runner
- **13.3.2.** Illegal run, illegal run play
- **13.3.3.** Illegal hand-off
- **13.3.4.** Illegal backward pass
- **13.3.5.** Jumping or diving
- **13.3.6.** Flag guarding

13.4. LOSS OF 5 YARDS
- **13.4.1.** Illegal snap
- **13.4.2.** Delay of game
- **13.4.3.** Illegal snap
- **13.4.4.** Encroachment, false start
- **13.4.5.** Illegal shift, illegal motion
- **13.4.6.** Offside, disconcerting signals, illegal blitzer signal
- **13.4.7.** Illegal rush
- **13.4.8.** Shielding
- **13.4.9.** Illegal flag pull
- **13.4.10.** Illegal kicking a pass
- **13.4.11.** Illegal participation
- **13.4.12.** Side line interference
- **13.4.13.** Charged timeout without a timeout left
- **13.4.14.** Illegal substitution

13.5. LOSS OF DOWN (LOD)
- **13.5.1.** Delay of pass
- **13.5.2.** Illegal touching

13.6. CHARGED TIMEOUT
- **13.6.1.** Players wearing illegal equipment not leaving field
- **13.6.2.** Players with missing mandatory equipment not leaving field
- **13.6.3.** Player with bleeding wound not leaving field
- **13.6.4.** Failed Challenge

14.0. Glossary

14.1. This alphabetical glossary is a quick-reference aid. It does not replace the formal Definitions section or the operative rule text. If there is any inconsistency, the Definitions section and the specific rule govern.

Term	Meaning
Aiming	Deliberate or avoidable forceful contact directed at an opponent, including contact made while attempting a flag pull or playing the ball.
All-Rounder (AR)	A player registered as eligible to play on both offense and defense. The player counts toward the on-field AR limit only when playing on the unit opposite the player's registered primary unit.
Automatic First Down (AFD)	A penalty result that awards the offense a new series.
Backward Pass / Lateral	A pass that is not forward. A pass parallel to the scrimmage line is a backward pass.
Ball Carrier	See Runner.
Basic Spot (BS)	The starting point used to enforce a penalty, as determined by the Penalty Enforcement rules.
Blitzer	A defender who establishes blitzer status with the required position and signal and immediately rushes in the manner required by rule.
Catch	Firm control of a live ball in flight, maintained through any contact with the ground required to complete the catch.
Centre	See Snapper.
Change of Team Possession (COP)	The point at which an opponent gains possession of the ball.
Dead Ball	A ball that is not in play.
Dead Ball Spot (DB)	The point at which the ball becomes dead.
Declared Punt	A punt announced to the Referee before the ready-for-play whistle.
Defense	The team opposing the team that puts the ball in play by a snap.
Dipping	A legal continuous lowering movement used by a runner to avoid a flag pull, provided it does not become illegal jumping or diving.
Disqualification / Ejection	Removal of a person from further participation in the game. Additional discipline may apply where stated by rule.
Down	The unit of play that begins with a legal snap, or the legal release of a declared punt throw, and ends when the ball becomes dead.
Enforcement Spot	The point from which a penalty is applied.
End Zone	The 10-yard area between a goal line and the corresponding end line.
Fake Hand-Off	A hand movement toward a nearby teammate that simulates transferring possession.
Fake Punt	A declared punt that converts into a normal fourth-down scrimmage play under the punt rules.

Term	Meaning
Female-Only Down	Every third down, on which all participating players must be female and the female-quarterback and ball requirements apply.
Flag Guarding	An illegal act by a runner that protects or makes a flag harder to reach by using the body, hand, arm, leg or ball.
Flag Pull	Removal of one or more of an opponent's flags by hand.
Forward Pass	A pass that first touches anything beyond the point from which it was released.
Forward Progress	The most advanced point of the ball when a runner's or airborne receiver's advancement ends and the ball becomes dead.
Foul	A rule infraction for which a penalty is prescribed.
Fumble	Loss of player possession by an act other than a pass or successful hand-off.
Game Ban	Ineligibility to participate in a stated number of the team's next official Showtime games.
Goal Line	The vertical plane separating the field of play from an end zone. The line and its pylons are in the end zone.
Hand-Off	A successful transfer of possession from one teammate to another that does not involve a pass.
Holding	Grasping an opponent or the opponent's equipment, failing to release immediately and affecting the opponent.
Illegal Contact	Prohibited intentional contact with an opponent or official.
Interception	A catch of an opponent's pass or fumble.
Live Ball	A ball in play, including a pass in flight that has not touched the ground.
Loss of Down (LOD)	Loss of the right to repeat the down; it applies only as provided by rule.
Middle Line / Middle	The line midway between the goal lines and the normal line to gain for a new series.
Motion	A change of position by one offensive player after a shift has ended and before the snap.
No-Running Zone	The marked area immediately in front of a goal line in which the running restrictions in these Playing Rules apply.
Offense	The team that puts the ball in play by a snap.
Out of Bounds	Outside the area enclosed by the side lines and end lines; the boundary lines themselves are out of bounds.
Pass Interference	Contact during a legal forward-pass play that unlawfully interferes with an eligible opponent while the ball is in the air.
Penalty	A consequence imposed for a foul, including yardage, loss of down, or disqualification.
Possession	Firm holding or control of a live ball.
Punt Throw	A legal Showtime fourth-down throw used to surrender possession under the declared-punt rules.
Punter	The eligible non-quarterback player designated to receive the punt snap and release the punt throw.

Term	Meaning
Ready for Play	The status created when the ball is placed on the ground and the Referee blows the ready-for-play whistle.
Referee	The official designated to lead the officiating crew and exercise final match authority under these Playing Rules.
Right of Place (ROP)	The protection held by a stationary player in a normal posture. It takes priority over right of way.
Right of Way (ROW)	The protection held by a player who establishes and maintains a lawful direction of movement, subject to right of place.
Runner	A player in possession of a live ball.
Rusher	A defender who legally crosses the scrimmage line without established blitzer status.
Sack	A legal flag pull from a quarterback in possession behind the scrimmage line; the punt rules separately govern a sack of the punter.
Safety	A scoring play in which the ball becomes dead on or behind a team's own goal line in circumstances specified by rule, or an accepted penalty leaves the ball there.
Series	Up to four consecutive scrimmage downs awarded to the team entitled to possession, subject to renewal or termination under the rules.
Shielding	Illegal non-contact obstruction by a moving player who does not have right of way.
Shift	A simultaneous change of position by two or more offensive players before the snap.
Snap	The legal backward transfer that puts the ball in play from scrimmage.
Snapper	The offensive player who snaps the ball; also referred to as the centre.
Spot of Foul (SF)	The point at which a foul occurs.
Scrimmage Line (SL)	The vertical plane through the point of the ready-for-play ball closest to a team's own goal line, extending to the side lines.
Throw-Off	The Showtime restart made by throwing the ball from the designated line at the beginning of a half or when otherwise authorised.
Touchback	A ruling that places the ball at the defending team's own 5-yard line after the ball becomes dead in its end zone in the circumstances specified by rule.
Touchdown	A score made when a runner in possession penetrates the opponent's goal-line plane or a player catches a pass in the opponent's end zone.
Try	The extra down after a touchdown on which either team may score the applicable point value.
Violation	A rule infraction for which no penalty is prescribed and which does not offset a foul.